2. Emergency drinking water — find, treat, store (English)

Oracle OS guide based on CDC, WHO, FEMA and IFRC guidance (see library: IFRC Household Water Treatment, WHO/WEDC notes, Practical Action SODIS).

How much

- At least **4 litres (1 gallon) per person per day** for drinking and cooking; more in heat, illness, pregnancy or hard work.
- Store at least **3 days** (72 hours); ideally 1–2 weeks. Remember pets.

Water already in your home

- Stored bottles; the **hot-water tank** (turn off power/gas, close the inlet, open the drain valve); the **toilet cistern** (tank, not bowl, and no coloured cleaners) — treat it; ice cubes; liquid in canned fruit and vegetables.
- House pipes: open the highest tap to let air in, collect from the lowest.
- **Never** drink untreated radiator, pool, central heating or flood water.

Treat it

1. **Settle and strain** cloudy water through a clean cloth or coffee filter (removes dirt only).
2. **Boil**: rolling boil for **1 minute** (3 minutes above 2,000 m). Most reliable against germs.
3. **Unscented household bleach** (5–6%): **2 drops per litre** (8 drops per gallon), stir, wait **30 minutes**. It should smell faintly of chlorine; if not, repeat and wait 15 more minutes. Double for cloudy or very cold water. Never use scented, gel or detergent bleach.
4. **Purification tablets**: follow the pack.
5. **SODIS**: clear PET bottles up to 2 L, clear water, direct sun for **6 hours** (2 days if cloudy).
6. **Portable filters** remove bacteria and protozoa; many do not remove viruses — add chlorine or boil if possible.

None of these remove fuel, chemicals or heavy metals. If water smells of fuel or looks oily or foamy, find another source.

Store it

Food-grade, clean, sealed containers away from sunlight and chemicals. Sanitise with 1 teaspoon of bleach per litre, rinse. Replace home-stored water every 6 months. Pour out — don't dip hands or cups in.

Rainwater

Clean roof and gutters, discard the first flush, cover the container, always treat before drinking.

Dehydration

Thirst, dark scanty urine, dizziness, dry mouth. Children: no tears, dry nappy. Give small frequent sips; for diarrhoea use oral rehydration salts (WHO home recipe if none: 1 litre safe water + 6 level teaspoons sugar + ½ level teaspoon salt).